

The Pike — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	White, firm, clean and genuinely excellent — comparable to walleye. The Y-bones are the whole of its bad reputation and they are entirely solvable. •••••
Texture	Firm and large-flaked, close to a cod. Holds together beautifully.
Best size	24–30 in. Big pike are coarser and are the breeders. The 26 in minimum here means you are keeping mid-size fish anyway.
Yield	About 30% by the five-fillet method — you deliberately sacrifice the Y-bone strip.
Slime	Pike are heavily slimed. Rinse in cold water before you start, and rinse the board between fish, or everything becomes slippery and dangerous.
Skin	Thick and strong. Comes off cleanly and is not eaten.

The five-fillet method — how to beat the Y-bones

A pike has an extra row of **Y-shaped intramuscular bones**, sitting above the lateral line in the *front half* of each fillet only. They are floating bones — they connect to nothing — so you cannot pull them like pin bones. You cut around them instead, and you deliberately give up a strip of meat. That is the whole trick, and it takes about two minutes once you have done it three times.

1. **Take two fillets normally.** Cut behind the gill plate to the backbone, turn the blade, run to the tail. Remove the ribs.
2. **Lay a fillet skin-side down.** Feel for the row of bone tips with a fingertip, running along the fillet slightly above the lateral line, from the head end back to roughly where the dorsal fin was — about the front 60% of the fillet. Behind that point there are none.
3. **Cut along the top of the Y-bones.** Starting at the head end, slice horizontally just *above* the bone tips, keeping the blade flat against them, until the cut runs out where the bones stop. This frees the whole upper-front section: **fillet one**, boneless.
4. **Cut along the bottom of the Y-bones.** Same again, this time just *below* the row, blade riding along the underside of the bones. This frees the lower-front section: **fillet two**, boneless.
5. **What is left** is a narrow strip containing every Y-bone, plus the rear third of the fillet which never had any. Cut the clean rear section off and keep it — **fillet three**.
6. Repeat on the other side. Five boneless pieces from one fish, and one bony strip that goes in the stockpot or the bin.

Bones and what to watch for

Y-bones	Above the lateral line, front 60% of the fillet only, floating and un-pullable. Cut above and below them, as in steps 3 and 4.
Do not try pliers	They break rather than pull, and you end up with bone fragments in the meat. This is the mistake everyone makes once.
The alternative	On smaller pike, score the fillet crossways every 3 mm down to the skin and deep-fry hot. The bones are fine enough to dissolve and become unnoticeable. It works, but the five-fillet method is better.
Pickling	Traditional and effective — the brine softens the Y-bones completely. Use a recipe with a boiling-water step, because the broad fish tapeworm is the one parasite in Wisconsin fish that matters to people.

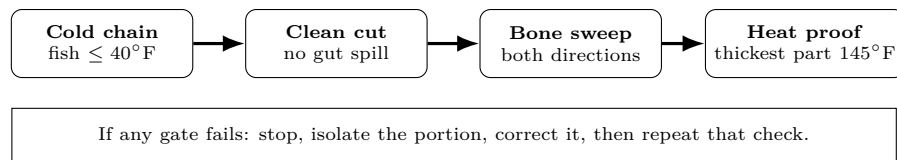
Cooking it

Method	How
Beer-battered	Pike is firm enough to take a proper batter. 375 °F, three to four minutes. Many people who say they dislike pike have only ever eaten it badly cleaned.
Poached	The firm flake suits gentle cooking. Court-bouillon or milk with bay and peppercorns, eight minutes at a bare simmer. Cold with mayonnaise the next day is better still.
Pickled	Cube the flesh, brine in salt for 48 hours, rinse, then cover in a boiled and cooled vinegar-sugar-pickling-spice solution with sliced onion. Two weeks in the fridge. The classic Wisconsin treatment and it makes the Y-bone problem vanish entirely.

Do this once with somebody watching

The five-fillet method is very hard to learn from words and very easy to learn from one demonstration. Do the first pike slowly, with a finger on the bone row the whole time so you can feel where the blade is. After two fish it becomes automatic, and pike goes from a fish people throw back to one of the best on the lake. *see the **Northern Pike** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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